

[Return to Search](#)

Disputed boundaries

Author(S): Rasmussen, Susan J.

Document Type: Article

Original Page: 353

Culture (OWC): [Tuareg \(MS25\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Northern Africa

Field Date: 1974-1991

Coverage Date: 1970-1990

Place Coverage: Niger

Section Title(S): KEL EWEY SOCIAL STRATIFICATION

Tuareg ethnicity is clearly complex and problematic. It often appears to merge with social stratum and occupation, but at times remains distinct. Different aspects of Tuareg identity neither exactly coincide nor stand as mutually exclusive. Consequently, Tuareg face a double-bind arising from contradictions between cultural values and economics. Pastoral nomadism is an attempt to resolve contradictions, but it is difficult to practice against pressures of erratic climate and nation-state politics. Yet it remains the cultural ideal among Tuareg who claim noble descent and consider it central to "true" Tuareg ethnic identity and noble class affiliation. They persist in calling themselves nomads regardless of actual occupation. How effective this mystique appears to the discrepancies between self-image and images held by others is illustrated when Tuareg from other divisions state emphatically that Kel Ewey are "not true Tuareg, but are more like Hausa." Inter-ethnic labelling between Kel Ewey and Hausa is also ambiguous and contradictory. The Hausa people cryptically refer to all Tuareg, nobles as well as former slaves, as *Buzuai*, a term Tuareg use only in reference to slaves and clients. Tuareg practice the converse of this; many refer to themselves, regardless of class origin, as *imajeghen* (noble). The task is to explore the construction of meaning and interpret these statements and glosses (nomad vs. sedentary gardener; "true Tuareg" vs. "more like Hausa;" noble vs. slave) against the backdrop of transformations in socioeconomic power bases and responses to them in cultural values and symbols. Are these mutual denigrations matter-of-fact markers, resentful insults, or affectionate jokes? As statements about identity and alterity, they inform broader issues; who constructs personhood, how it is constructed and information managed, and how far it is shared by the different social segments it affects.

121
Theoretical
Orientation

181
Ethos

182
Functional/Adaptational
Interpretations

186
Cultural Identity And
Pride

233
Pastoral Activities

629
Multi-Ethnic
Community Relations

This relates to studies of other/alterity: to the concern of decentering of pronominal use in anthropological discourse (Clifford and Marcus 1986; Marcus and Fischer 1986). Maranhao (1991:65–73) terms this issue "the question of the object of anthropological inquiry: who are we representing when we study a culture? How does one demarcate boundaries, and on what basis are these drawn? The major issue is who decides. Nomadism is still central to noble Kel Ewey ideology and identity because it has been elevated as the emblem of personhood, a more tolerable ideal superimposed upon ethnicity and social stratum where these latter are not clear markers of status and prestige. Many persons of servile origins today own camels and enjoy prosperity. Pastoral nomadism becomes a medium of communication to underline status distinctions, but subordinate groups at times offer subtle rebuttals to this formulation, thereby mitigating its effectiveness.

121
Theoretical
Orientation

186
Cultural Identity And
Pride

233
Pastoral Activities

This discourse occurs in wedding rituals among nobles in Kel Ewey Tuareg communities. At sundown, the groom's family arrives at the home of the bride riding elaborately decorated camels, where they are formally greeted. The following day, blacksmiths attached in client-patron relationships to noble families ■354 of the region sing praise-songs while men race their camels back and forth and then make the camels dance. (Formerly only nobles owned camels, nowadays descendants of slaves may also own them. At all marriages, bridewealth is one camel.) Next, men of diverse origins approach the circle of singing smiths, each offering money, tea, sugar, and millet, while smiths mock each social segment. The men perform dances identified with different social strata; for example, noble men do a dance called "Foot, do nothing," as smiths lament, "feet without shoes," and sing "I do not want jealousy of slaves or smiths." Ex-clients perform a rapid hopping dance on one leg in steps compared to "sugar melting in the mouth." Smiths sing, "Word follows word (rapidly), the hide of gazelles is tanned, but not greased," alluding to client dancers' near-servile status. This ritual mutual and self-debasement evokes servitude yet simultaneously separates and brings together the different social segments, suggesting their mutual dependence, but also attempts to "keep people in their (proper) places." The different social segments come together genially to exaggerate their affection, yet the dances and pastoralist imagery evoke the contradictions inherent in Kel Ewey society. Joking and familiarity are practiced between nobles, smiths, and former slaves, who are not supposed to intermarry. But joking is also practiced between cross-cousins, who are potential marriage partners, and in certain contexts smiths and former slaves are said to be "like cousins to nobles." It is the medium of communication that provides insights into this dialogue on personal identity.

121
Theoretical
Orientation

186
Cultural Identity And
Pride

554
Status, Role, And
Prestige

585
Nuptials

628
Inter-Community
Relations

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)